War and Peace – A Collection

By Israeli, Palestinian and One American Poet

A Soldier Wept on the Radio by Tzippi Shahrur

(Israeli)

On the radio a soldier was weeping,

"I've never killed a human being before,"

and amplified sobbing shook me.

And it was no longer necessary

to be ashamed.

Soldier,

what strength you had

to weep in the listeners' numbed ears,

"I've never even killed an ant," you pleaded.

Well, who hasn't. . . but a man. . .

So I was with you

on the radio in that unsung hour

between a rock song and the news

when you mourned your enemy

into a microphone that was still alive.

4NG Fanatics

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Tzippi Shahrur
Book: After the First Rain: Israeli Poems on War and Peace
ISBN: 978-0815605249
Publisher: Syracuse University Press
Date (Month/Year): Feb 1998

Also Online at
https://www.pressenterprise.com/2023/11/17/the-poetry-of-war-and-peace-by-israeli-and-palestinian-poets/

INTRODUCTION

How many times? How many wars? How many times must history repeat itself, creating wounds that will never heal and generations of victims who know nothing but violence and revenge. So many times, humanity has promised itself – never again and yet here we are – Again.

I cannot be silent about the innocent civilians taken hostage in Israel and fleeing for their lives in Gaza. With so many political and military actions tearing us apart we have to remember what ties us together. Our humanity. Our hope for a better future. If there is a choice between War and Peace . . . I will always choose peace.

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And My Brother Said Nothing
(aka My Brother Was Silent) by Amir Gilboa *(Israeli)*

My brother came back from the field
Dressed in gray. And I was afraid that
My dream might prove false, so at once
I began to count his wounds.
And my brother said nothing.

Then I rummaged in the pockets of the trench coat
And found a field-dressing, stained and dry.
And on frayed postcard, her name –
Beneath a picture of poppies.
And my brother said nothing.

Then I undid the pack
And took out his belongings, memory by memory.
Hurrah, my brother, my brother, the hero,
Now I've found your decorations!
Hurrah, my brother, my brother, the hero,
I shall proudly hymn your name!
And my brother said nothing.
And my brother said nothing.

His blood was crying out from the ground.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Amir Gilboa
Book: After the First Rain: Israeli Poems on War and Peace
ISBN: 978-0815605249
Publisher: Syracuse University Press
Date (Month/Year): Feb 1998

Also Online at https://azm.org/yom-hazikaron-readings/

TRANSITION

Mosab Abu Toha, a Palestinian refugee and celebrated poet wrote this poem last year, reflecting on his childhood under Israeli military occupation. Released by Israeli forces on November 21, 2023, he is currently struggling to survive in a United Nations refugee camp, with his wife and three children.

Younger Than War
by Mosab Abu Toha *(Palestinian)*

Tanks roll through dust, through eggplant fields.
Beds unmade, lightening in the sky, brother
jumps to the window to watch warplanes
flying through clouds of smoke
after air strikes. Warplanes that look like eagles
searching for a tree branch to perch on,
catch breath, but these metal eagles

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are catching souls in a blood/bone soup bowl.

No need for radio.

We are the news.

Ants' ears hurt with each bullet

fired from wrathful machine guns.

Soldiers advance, burn books, some smoke

rolled sheets of yesterday's newspaper, just like they did

when they were kids. Our kids

hide in the basement, backs against concrete pillars,

heads between knees, parents silent.

Humid down there, and heat of burning bombs

adds up to the slow death

of survival.

In September 2000, after I had bought bread for dinner,

I saw a helicopter firing a rocket

into a tower as far from me as my frightful cries

when I heard concrete and glass fall from high.

Loaves of bread went stale.

I was still 7 at the time.

I was decades younger than war,

a few years older than bombs.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Mosab Abu Toha
ISBN: On-line Transcript
https://www.theatlantic.com/books/archive/2023/11/poem-mosab-abu-toha-younger-war/675944/
Publisher: The Atlantic
Date (Month/Year): Nov 9, 2023

Truce by Zelda Mishkovsky *(Israeli)*

A simple motion of the hand

cancels the torture, a motion

belonging to a suicide wolf—

a zealous youth who suddenly

was fed up with hate

because his soul revealed:

hatred lies

hatred lies

hatred lies—

and the force

of that thought, swelling with

the voice of childhood,

of miracles, broke through

to an untried path. The primordial

goodness welled up in him

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and he saved the prisoner.

A river burst forth

from the Eden of his inwardness.

He offered the prisoner water, restoring

him in the desert. Slowly the monster

of revenge recedes and fresh

worlds appear, overflowing with water.

Alas! They both know:

This is not the whole truth,

this is a small truce in a green

island, that island which is

beyond every nation, whatever

its origin.

But on this island, in a dark cave,

Peace opened its eyes.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Amir Gilboa
Book: After the First Rain: Israeli Poems on War and Peace
ISBN: 978-0815605249
Publisher: Syracuse University Press
Date (Month/Year): Feb 1998

Also online at
https://www.pressenterprise.com/2023/11/17/the-poetry-of-war-and-peace-by-israeli-and-palestinian-poets/

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TRANSITION

In 2018 around 30 young and aspiring poets came together to form the Gaza Poets Society. In May 2021 their meeting place, a library and the largest bookstore in Gaza, was the target of an Israeli missile strike and completely destroyed. Nadine Murtaja, one of the Gaza poets was 18 then and wrote this poem in response to the missile strike. It documents the eeriness of life under siege, recording how, even during bombardment, hope persists: Today, according to her Facebook page she is a dental student at Al-Azhar University.

We Walk on The Shattered Glass of Our Broken Windows by Nadine Murtaja *(Palestinian)*

There, on the other side,

time changes, hours pass, and it gets darker,

the sky takes off its dim dress, then the morning arrives,

but here where I live and breathe, life wears its black dress

constantly,

to mourn the labor of my land, which took a long time.

Here, the hanging clock in my room is broken,

and not only this one, everyone's clock is broken here,

my mother keeps saying: everyone is waiting for the elixir

we've had it with grief and agony,

in this holy land we sleep and wake up to sounds

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of bombing and shooting,

so the first light of day rises in the evening,

lighting up the sky with the blood of martyrs,

here death sleeps not far from us,

we all walk towards freedom, towards hope,

we walk on the shattered glass of our broken windows,

we walk on stones that once were a house, carrying stories

and secrets,

we walk with the screams of children, and the groans of

mothers pulsing over and over in our ears.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Nadine Murtaja
ISBN: On-Line Transcript
https://www.thenews.com.pk/magazine/us/1129276-poets-corner
Publisher: The International News
Date (Month/Year): Posted Oct 16, 2023

TRANSITION

What would you do to help a child – any child – feel safe in a time of war. Imagine holding them in your arms as you hide behind a pile of rubble. What words would you whisper to a child under siege?

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Words Whispered to a Child Under Seige by Joseph Fasano *(American)*

No, we are not going to die.

The sounds you hear

knocking the windows and chipping the paint

from the ceiling, that is a game

the world is playing.

Our task is to crouch in the dark as long as we can

and count the beats of our own hearts.

Good. Like that. Lay your hand

on my heart and I'll lay mine on yours.

Which one of us wins

is the one who loves the game the most

while it lasts.

Yes, it is going to last.

You can use your ear instead of your hand.

Here, on my heart.

Why is it beating faster? For you. That's all.

I always wanted you to be born

and so did the world.

No, those aren't a stranger's bootsteps in the house.

Yes, I'm here. We're safe.

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Remember chess? Remember

hide-and-seek?

The song your mother sang? Let's sing that one.

She's still with us, yes. But you have to sing

without making a sound. She'd like that.

No, those aren't bootsteps.

Sing. Sing louder.

Those aren't bootsteps.

Let me show you how I cried when you were born.

Those aren't bootsteps.

Those aren't sirens.

Those aren't flames.

Close your eyes. Like chess. Like hide-and-seek.

When the game is done you get another life.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Joseph Fasano
ISBN: On-line Transcript
https://www.upworthy.com/powerful-poem-parenting-in-war-zone
Publisher: Upworthy.com
Date (Month/Year): October 25, 2023

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